

ANXIETY



UNDERSTANDING ANXIETY

Worrying about lots of things, people, and places (e.g. family, community, grief, loss, trauma, shame, home, hospital, school, Centrelink, workplace, parks, pools, and sports fields,) can make us feel what some call 'Anxiety'. Anxiety is something that anyone can feel, even our mob. Anxiety can affect anyone, in any community, in different ways.

This fact sheet shares some types of things that might make us worry or feel 'anxious', and ways that respect our culture for dealing with these worries and feelings. It is important to remember the things that can make us feel this way and use ways from our culture to feel better.

WHAT CAN ANXIETY FEEL LIKE?

Common signs and symptoms of anxiety include:

- Feeling nervous, restless or tense
- Having a sense of impending danger, panic or doom
- Having an increased heart rate
- Breathing rapidly (hyperventilation)
- Sweating
- Trembling
- Feeling weak or tired
- Trouble concentrating or thinking about anything other than the present worry
- Having trouble sleeping
- Experiencing gastrointestinal (GI) problems
- Having difficulty controlling worry
- Having the urge to avoid things that trigger anxiety



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CONTRIBUTING FACTORS TO ANXIETY

WHAT MAKES US WORRY?

Many things can make us feel worried in our mob. Some of these are:

- 1. *Lateral Violence:*** A form of bullying that includes gossip, shaming and blaming others, backstabbing and attempts to socially isolate others.
- 2. *Loss of Culture:*** Losing our languages, or if we can't get to our lands, we might feel worried and not good.
- 3. *Old Hurts, intergenerational trauma:*** Bad things from long ago, like when they took away children, or treated us unfair, can hurt us still. These hurts can pass through families and make us worry more.
- 4. *Life Troubles:*** Not having enough money, not having good health care, schools, or homes can make our worries worse.
- 5. *Being Treated Bad:*** When people are racist or unfair to us, this can hurt our minds and make us worry.
- 6. *Losing Our Identity:*** When we don't know our culture, can't connect with our family, or feel the hurt of the old ways, we can lose ourselves and feel worried.

HEALING OUR SPIRIT AND HOW TO FEEL BETTER

To feel less worried, we can use ways that make sense to us. Some ways are:



Bring Back Our Ways: Doing our cultural things, like speaking our language, making art, dancing, and sharing stories can make us feel good and less worried.



Connect with Our Country: Being on our country, doing things there, and feeling the bush can make us feel better and less worried.



Our Ways of Healing: Using our old ways of healing, like bush medicine and our spiritual ways, together with new ways can make us feel whole and less worried.



Support from Our Mob: Having good friends, listening to our Elders, and going to gatherings can make us feel cared for and like we belong.



Strength from Our Ways: Using our cultural wisdom, spirit, and Dreamtime stories can give us strength to deal with our worries in ways that make sense to us.



Seeking out health care: If your worry gets really bad and none of the above ideas help, you can go to your local Aboriginal Medical Service (AMS), doctor, or hospital.

Worry is something that we all can feel, even in our mob in Indigenous communities. By knowing the things that make us worry and using ways that respect our culture, we can deal with these worries and feel better. Bringing back our ways, getting support from our mob, and using our healing ways can help us deal with our worries in a way that respects our culture and values. Remember, there are people who can help, and you're not alone in this walk towards feeling better.



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